RAG Learning

Edexcel GCSE Geography B (1GB0) — Component 1: Global Geographical Issues · Topic 3: Challenges of an Urbanising World

1.5 Challenges of an Urbanising World

1. Global Urbanisation Trends

Urbanisation: The process by which an **increasing proportion** of a country's population comes to live in urban areas (towns and cities). It is measured as the percentage of total population living in urban areas — NOT the total number of people in cities.

Key Global Statistics

Year	% Urban Population (global)	Urban Population (approx.)
1950	30%	750 million
2007	50%	3.3 billion (first time majority urban)
2018	55%	4.2 billion
2050 (projected)	68%	~6.7 billion

Urbanisation rates vary dramatically by development level:

Region	% Urban (2020)	Trend
North America	82%	Slow growth; some counter-urbanisation
Europe	75%	Slow growth; some re-urbanisation (gentrification)

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Latin America & Caribbean	81%	Largely already urbanised; growth slowing
Asia	51%	Rapid urbanisation ongoing — China, India, SE Asia
Africa	43%	Fastest urbanisation globally — doubling expected by 2050

Megacities

Megacity: A city with a population exceeding **10 million people**. In 1990 there were 10 megacities; by the mid-2020s there were over 30 (the UN counted 33 in 2025). Most growth in megacities now occurs in developing and emerging countries.

City	Country	Population (urban agglomeration)	Classification
Tokyo	Japan	~37.4 million	Developed country — long ranked the world's largest city (a 2025 UN report using a new city definition ranked Jakarta and Dhaka larger)
Delhi	India	~32.9 million	Emerging country — one of the fastest growing megacities
Shanghai	China	~29 million	Emerging country
São Paulo	Brazil	~22.4 million	Emerging country
Mumbai	India	~21 million	Emerging country
Lagos	Nigeria	~15 million	Emerging country (lower-middle income) — one of Africa's largest cities
London	UK	~9.5 million	Developed country

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Exam Tip: The distinction between urbanisation and urban growth is a classic exam trap. Urbanisation = increasing *proportion* living in cities. Urban growth = increasing *number*. A city can grow in absolute population without urbanisation occurring if the rural population grows at the same rate. State both clearly in high-mark answers.

2. Megacities and World Cities

Megacity — a city with a population of over 10 million. **World city** — a city with global influence in finance, trade, culture and politics (e.g. London, New York, Tokyo, Paris), which may or may not be a megacity.

- In 1950 there were just two megacities (New York and Tokyo); by the mid-2020s there were over 30, most in Asia, Africa and Latin America.
- World cities are linked by flows of money, people, goods and information — they are hubs in the global economy.

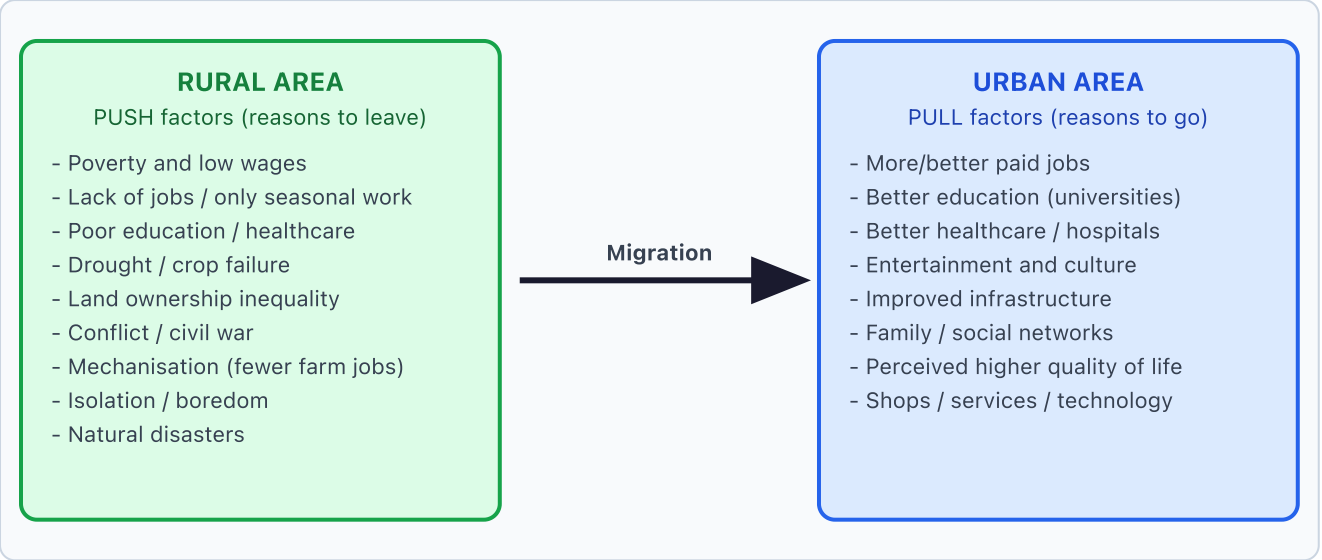
Urbanisation in developed, emerging and developing countries

Type of country	Urbanisation pattern
Developed (e.g. UK)	Already about 80–85% urban; slow growth; some counter-urbanisation and re-urbanisation (people returning to regenerated city centres)
Emerging (e.g. India, Brazil)	Rapid urbanisation driven by industrialisation and rural–urban migration; growth of megacities
Developing (e.g. Niger)	Lower proportion urban but some of the fastest growth rates; high natural increase in cities

3. Causes of Urbanisation

Urbanisation results from two processes: **rural-urban migration** (people moving from countryside to city) and **natural increase** (birth rate exceeding death rate within cities).

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution



Push-Pull Factors in Depth — With Statistics

Push-pull theory (Ravenstein, 1885) explains migration as driven by negative conditions at origin and positive conditions at destination. In reality, migration decisions are complex and shaped by personal networks, distance, cost, and government policies.

Push Factor	Supporting Evidence
Agricultural mechanisation reducing farm jobs	In India, agricultural employment fell from 60% of the workforce in 2000 to ~42% by 2020 (World Bank), as millions left farming for urban jobs.
Land inequality / landlessness	In Brazil in the 1970s–1990s, the top 1% of landowners held over 44% of agricultural land, pushing landless rural workers towards cities like São Paulo.
Climate shocks and drought	The 2009–2011 drought in the Sahel affected 10 million people; climate change could create 216 million internal climate migrants globally by 2050, 86 million of them in sub-Saharan Africa (World Bank, 2021).
Low rural wages	In Nigeria, rural farm incomes are typically far below urban earnings; the national minimum wage (₦30,000/month from 2019, raised to ₦70,000 in 2024) mainly applies to formal urban jobs, and even informal urban work often pays more than rural agriculture.

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Conflict and instability	Syria's civil war (from 2011) displaced 6 million internally; many fled to Damascus, Aleppo, and eventually abroad. Northeast Nigeria's Boko Haram insurgency has displaced over 2 million people, mostly to towns and cities within the north-east such as Maiduguri.

Pull Factor	Supporting Evidence
Higher urban wages	The urban wage premium in developing countries is typically 15–30% above rural wages for equivalent work, and up to 200% for skilled urban jobs (ILO data).
Better education access	In Nigeria, urban areas have ~3x more secondary schools per capita than rural areas; university access is almost exclusively urban.
Healthcare	Under-5 mortality in rural Nigeria is much higher than in urban areas (NDHS, 2018) — a powerful pull for young families.
Social networks / family chain migration	Migrants follow established networks — a family member or friend who has already migrated reduces the cost, risk, and uncertainty of moving. This explains why migration streams often link specific rural regions to specific cities.
Perceived opportunity	Even the informal economy in Lagos or Mumbai offers more diverse income opportunities than subsistence farming — hawking, domestic work, construction, and petty trade all provide income that is irregular but potentially higher than rural work.

Exam Tip: When asked about push-pull factors, avoid listing them without context. Examiners at higher grades reward analysis: explain *why* a factor is significant (e.g. "Mechanisation is particularly powerful because it permanently removes jobs, leaving no reason to stay — unlike drought, which is temporary"). Use the word "because" repeatedly to force explanation rather than description.

Natural Increase in Cities

In developing and emerging countries, cities also grow through **natural increase** — a higher birth rate than death rate within the urban population. Migrants are often young adults (reproductive age), which raises the urban birth rate. Improved healthcare in cities reduces child mortality compared to rural areas.

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

In Lagos, for example, the natural increase rate is approximately 3% per year — meaning even without migration, the city would double in population within 23 years.

Developed country vs developing/emerging Urbanisation

Feature	Developed countries (e.g. UK, USA)	Developing and emerging countries (e.g. India, Nigeria)
Stage of urbanisation	Already highly urbanised (75–85%); growth slowing or reversing	Rapidly urbanising; some cities growing at 3–5% per year
Main driver	Economic restructuring; suburbanisation/counter-urbanisation now prevalent	Rural-urban migration + high natural increase
Key challenge	Urban decay, deprivation, housing affordability, congestion	Insufficient housing, services, infrastructure for rapid population growth
Squatter settlements?	Rare / managed	Very common — ~1 billion people globally live in informal settlements
Historical timing	Urbanisation occurred gradually over 150+ years (Industrial Revolution from 1760s) allowing infrastructure to develop in parallel	Rapid urbanisation compressed into decades — infrastructure cannot keep up
Government capacity	Strong planning systems, building regulations, welfare provision	Often insufficient revenue, corruption, weak enforcement of planning law

4. Urbanisation in developing and emerging countries — Squatter Settlements

Squatter settlement / Informal settlement / Slum: A densely populated area of a city where housing has been **illegally built** on land not owned by the residents, using temporary materials, without official permission. Known by various local names: *favela* (Brazil), *barrio* (Latin America), *shanty town* (general), *bidonville* (French Africa), *bustee* (India).

Why Do Squatter Settlements Develop?

- Rural-urban migrants arrive in cities faster than formal housing can be built
- Migrants cannot afford formal sector rents or house prices
- Land on the city periphery, flood plains, steep hillsides, or near railways/factories is undesirable — squatters occupy it with less risk of eviction
- Governments in developing countries lack resources to provide social housing at scale
- Informal settlements develop incrementally — start with temporary shelters, gradually improve over years

Characteristics of Squatter Settlements

Feature	Detail
Housing	Built from salvaged materials — corrugated iron, plastic sheets, cardboard, breeze blocks. Often 1–2 rooms for extended families.
Water supply	Often no piped water; residents buy from water vendors at 10× the price paid by formal city residents, or use shared/contaminated sources
Sanitation	Few or no toilets/sewers; open sewers or defecation in the open; very high disease risk (cholera, typhoid, diarrhoea)
Electricity	Often illegally tapped from nearby power lines; fire risk; unreliable
Employment	Mostly informal economy — street vending, waste picking, domestic work, small manufacturing
Security	No legal title to land; constant threat of eviction; high crime rates in some areas

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Health	High rates of respiratory disease (overcrowding, cooking fires); waterborne diseases; malnutrition; high infant mortality
Global scale	Approximately 1 billion people (1 in 7 globally) live in informal settlements (UN Habitat)

5. Case Study: Mumbai, India (emerging country) — Squatter Settlements and Improvement

Case Study: Mumbai (emerging country) — Urbanisation, Slums, and Improvement

Location and status: Mumbai (formerly Bombay) is India's financial capital, located on the west coast. It is India's largest city with ~12.5 million people in Greater Mumbai (2011 census) and over 20 million in the wider metropolitan region. It is one of the world's most densely populated cities. Around 40–50% of Mumbai's population lives in informal settlements occupying under 10% of the city's land area.

Why it grew so rapidly: Mumbai was the centre of British colonial trade (textiles, finance); post-independence it became India's financial and entertainment (Bollywood) hub. Millions migrated from rural Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, and Bihar seeking work and better wages.

Dharavi — Key Data: Located in central Mumbai, Dharavi covers approximately 2.1 km² and is home to an estimated 600,000–1 million people — making it one of Asia's most densely populated areas and one of its largest informal settlements.

- **Population density:** Up to 300,000 people per km² — approximately 10 times the density of Manhattan, New York
- **Sanitation crisis:** 1 toilet per ~1,440 residents (compared to UN standard of 1 per 50)
- **Living space:** Most homes are 10–15 m² housing 5–10 people
- **Average income:** Approximately $500 per year — well below Mumbai's average of ~$3,000
- **Child health:** Infant mortality in Dharavi is approximately 68 per 1,000 live births vs. 36 per 1,000 for Mumbai as a whole
- **Education:** An estimated 25% of children in Dharavi do not attend school regularly; many work in family businesses

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Dharavi's informal economy: Despite its challenges, Dharavi is a productive economic zone with an estimated annual turnover of **$600–700 million USD**. It contains ~15,000 single-room factories and 5,000 businesses including:

- **Recycling:** Processes up to 80% of Mumbai's plastic waste; workers (called "kabariwalas") sort and sell recyclables
- **Leather goods:** Many bags and accessories sold globally are produced in Dharavi workshops
- **Pottery (Kumbharwada):** Traditional pottery quarter has operated for over 100 years
- **Food production and garment manufacturing**

This demonstrates that informal settlements are not simply places of poverty — they are functional communities with complex economies.

Dharavi Redevelopment Project: A proposed redevelopment (approved in principle 2022, led by the Adani Group) aims to rehouse all residents in modern apartment blocks on the same site, while building additional flats for sale on the open market to fund the project. Critics argue: community businesses and social networks will be destroyed; many residents will not qualify for free housing due to technicalities; high-rise living may not suit residents' occupational needs (potters, leather workers need ground-floor space). Supporters say it will deliver piped water, sewage, electricity, and schools to all residents.

Squatter Settlement Improvement Schemes

Three main approaches are used by governments and NGOs to improve informal settlements:

Approach	How it works	Advantages	Disadvantages
Self-Help Schemes (SHS)	Government provides materials (bricks, cement, roofing), legal land tenure, loans, and technical advice; residents build/improve homes themselves	Cheaper per family than government-built housing; community ownership and investment; preserves social networks; houses tailored to residents' needs	Quality depends on residents' skills; can be slow; corruption in allocation; may exclude the poorest who cannot contribute labour

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Site and Service Schemes	Government provides serviced plots (road access, basic water supply, sewerage connection) and residents build their own home on the plot	More affordable than completed housing; residents invest in and maintain their own property; builds permanent community; used widely in East Africa and South Asia	Residents still bear building costs; initial site may lack full services; risk of subletting or resale to higher-income groups ("elite capture")
Slum Clearance / Forced Relocation	Government demolishes informal settlement and rehouses residents in purpose-built blocks elsewhere in the city	Can deliver high-quality permanent housing quickly; clears land for infrastructure development; improves area statistics	Destroys community and economic networks; new housing often far from residents' workplaces; high-rise flats unsuitable for families with outdoor businesses; residents may return to new slums; social trauma; often used to clear land for commercial development rather than residents' benefit

Mumbai — Slum Rehabilitation Authority (SRA) Data:

- Established 1995; has rehoused an estimated 600,000+ slum dwellers in permanent buildings under the Slum Rehabilitation Scheme
- The scheme provides free flats (raised to 300 sq ft / ~28 m² in 2016) to qualifying slum dwellers; developers are rewarded with additional "sale component" apartments for the market
- Despite this, Mumbai still has thousands of slum pockets, home to an estimated 5–6 million people
- **Criticism:** Many residents are excluded for not meeting the "cutoff date" criteria (originally residents had to have lived there before 1 January 1995, later extended to 2000); the small flats are considered too small for families; buildings have had maintenance problems and lift failures

Exam Tip — Squatter Settlement Questions: Exam questions often ask you to "evaluate" improvement schemes. Always discuss at least two approaches and weigh pros vs. cons. The key

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

evaluative point is that self-help and site-and-service schemes respect community agency, while slum clearance often serves developer or government interests more than residents. Support with specific Dharavi or Mumbai SRA data for top marks.

6. Mumbai: Top-Down and Bottom-Up Strategies

Strategy	Type	Detail and evaluation
Dharavi Redevelopment Project	Top-down	A government-backed plan (led by the Adani Group since 2022) to rehouse residents in high-rise flats and redevelop the land. It could improve sanitation and housing, but many residents fear losing their workshops and community, and those who cannot prove residence may be excluded.
Mumbai Metro and coastal road	Top-down	New metro lines and the Mumbai Coastal Road reduce congestion and journey times, but are very expensive and have displaced some residents and fishing communities.
SPARC and Mahila Milan	Bottom-up	An NGO and a network of women's savings groups that help slum dwellers build community toilet blocks, save money and negotiate with the city for housing. Low-cost and community-led, but small in scale.
Slum Sanitation Programme	Partnership	Hundreds of community toilet blocks built with communities who maintain them through small fees — improving health at low cost.

Exam Tip: Edexcel asks you to evaluate top-down and bottom-up strategies for improving quality of life in your megacity. Use one of each and finish with a judgement — many geographers argue that the most successful schemes combine government funding with community participation.

7. Urban Issues in developing and emerging countries

Issue	Detail	Example

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution

Traffic congestion	Rapid motorisation as incomes rise; poor road infrastructure; mixed traffic (pedestrians, rickshaws, cars, buses); poor public transport	Mumbai: average commute speed 12 km/h in peak hours; Delhi: among the most congested cities globally (TomTom); Lagos: commuters spend average 4+ hours in traffic daily
Air pollution	Vehicle exhaust (older, poorly maintained vehicles); industrial emissions; domestic cooking fires; construction dust	Delhi: PM2.5 levels regularly 10–20× WHO safe limit; "AQI hazardous" for weeks in winter; air pollution was linked to about 1.7 million deaths in India in 2019. Lagos: vehicle emissions worsened by fuel quality (high-sulphur diesel)
Inadequate sanitation	Insufficient sewage infrastructure; open sewers; rivers used as open sewers	Dharavi: 1 toilet per 1,440 people; Mithi River in Mumbai severely polluted; Makoko (Lagos): sewage directly into lagoon
Water supply	Pipes inadequate; contamination; inequitable supply (rich areas get piped water, poor pay vendors); groundwater over-extraction	Lagos: formal supply only 30% of need; Mumbai gets water for only 2–4 hours/day in many areas; Jakarta sinking due to groundwater extraction
Waste management	Insufficient formal collection; illegal dumping; open landfills; burning of waste	Lagos: Olusosun landfill critically overcapacity; waste pickers (informal recyclers) handle much of the city's waste; Dharavi processes 80% of Mumbai's plastic waste informally
Crime and insecurity	Poverty, inequality, unemployment — especially youth unemployment — drives property crime and gang activity	São Paulo: gang-related violence; Lagos: "area boys" gangs controlling markets; rapid decline in murder rate in some favelas following targeted social programmes

© RAG Learning · Not for redistribution